

BLOOMING TEA

Blooming teas, or flower teas as they are also known, consist of fresh flowers encased in white tea leaves. When steeped, the bloom unfurls to reveal the flowers within.

Originating in the Fujian province of China, blooming teas are made by nimble-fingered women, who can make up to 400 blooms per day. With twists and turns of leaves, flowers, and thread, they produce compact balls of tea, about $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2cm) in diameter.

White Silver Needle buds, which have been processed as green tea, are used for this process, as the young leaves are pliable, easy to work with, and look good while infusing. First, the leaves are carefully tied together at the base. Then, dried flowers, such as osmanthus, jasmine, chrysanthemum, lily, or marigold, are threaded together and bound with the tea leaves. The order in which the flowers are arranged will determine the style of the bloom.

Some styles symbolize happiness, prosperity, or love, while others portray concepts, such as a flower blooming in spring. The blooms are

then bound together at the top and wrapped in cloth to hold them until they are heated, at a very high temperature, to secure their shape.

When selecting blooming tea, look for leaves that are whole, and flower colors that are not too pale. Blooming teas look best when they are prepared in a glass teapot, but you can also use a preheated tall tumbler or glass pitcher. Place the bloom in a teapot. Heat the water to 170–175°F (75–80°C) and pour slowly over the bloom, filling two-thirds of the teapot. After 1–2 minutes, the bloom will begin to open and reveal the flowers and colors within.

As the white buds have been processed in the same way as green tea, you can expect several infusions from each bloom. Once you have consumed the tea, you can continue to display the flower for several days in a jug of fresh, cold water.

AN EXPERIENCED
CRAFTSPERSON CAN
TIE MORE THAN 400
BLOOMS A DAY

